

# Good Bones vs. Expensive Problems

Before you fall for the tile, separate cosmetic work from the systems that can change your budget, timeline and ability to insure the house. This is the first-pass framework I use before a professional inspection.

## 01

### The Expensive Stuff

- **Structure + water:** stair-step cracks, sloping floors, sticking doors, retaining walls, musty areas and poor drainage deserve specialist eyes.
- **Roof + exterior:** verify age, flashing, gutters, stucco and signs of active or repaired leaks—appearance alone does not establish remaining life.
- **Systems:** identify panel capacity and wiring type, supply and drain materials, HVAC age, duct condition and water-heater installation.
- **Site:** slope, large trees near foundations or sewer lines, and hazard-zone location can change both repair and insurance math.

CHECK FIRST

## 02

### The Mostly Cosmetic Stuff

- Paint color, cabinet fronts, hardware, light fixtures and dated tile can create a dramatic first impression without being structural.
- Worn flooring and tired landscaping are usually scopeable projects—measure the quantity and price the exact material you want.
- “Cosmetic” still needs testing: stains can signal moisture, and pre-1978 painted surfaces may require lead-safe renovation practices.
- Do not assume popcorn texture is harmless or expensive; test suspect materials before disturbance and price the result.

LOOK PAST IT

## 03

### The Layout + Legal Reality

- Test daily flow, natural light, ceiling height, storage and privacy—not just bedroom and bathroom count.
- Moving a wall may involve structure; moving kitchens or baths adds plumbing, electrical, venting and permit work.
- Match additions, converted garages and extra rooms to city permit records. Undocumented space can affect financing, appraisal and resale.
- Before counting an ADU, bedroom or bath in your plan, confirm what is legally recognized and what can actually be permitted.

HARD TO CHANGE



FROM JULIA

*“The house with the ugly kitchen and good bones will always beat the house with the beautiful kitchen and bad ones.”*

You can always change a kitchen.

#### BEFORE YOU COMMIT

Six checks that turn a fixer idea into a defensible budget.

##### CHECK 01

#### Bring the right specialists early.

A general inspector is the starting point. Add foundation, roof, chimney, pool, drainage or HVAC specialists when the house gives you a reason. Scope the private sewer lateral too—roots, cracks, offsets and bellies hide underground.

##### CHECK 02

#### Match the house to official records.

Review permits, planning cases and code history in ZIMAS/LADBS. Ask whether permits reached final approval. For pre-1978 paint, plan for lead-safe practices; also check fire, flood and seismic layers.

##### CHECK 03

#### Verify contractors + compare the same scope.

Check license status and complaint disclosures with CSLB. Get three written bids based on the same plans, materials and work—not three vague totals that cannot be compared.

##### CHECK 04

#### Build the real all-in number.

Add plans, engineering, permits, temporary housing and a 15–20% contingency to the written construction bids. Confirm insurance cost and availability before removing contingencies. Your offer should work with that total—not the dream number.